



Hamilton School for  
Classical and Civic Education  
UNIVERSITY *of* FLORIDA

# A Conflict of Visions

*ISS 2440 — Intro to PPEL*  
*Week 1*

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August 21, 2026

## Bertrand Russell

*“Every man, wherever he goes, is encompassed by a cloud of comforting convictions, which move with him like flies on a summer day.”*

— Epigraph to Thomas Sowell, *A Conflict of Visions*

- ▶ Tell me your view of the **minimum wage**; I will predict your view of **bail reform**.

## Minimum wage

- ▶ One side asks: *What is the just wage?*
- ▶ Other side asks: *What trade-offs does a price floor create?*
- ▶ Same data; different visions.

## Crime / bail reform

- ▶ One side: find the *root causes* and solve them.
- ▶ Other side: crime is a permanent tendency; deter at the margin.

## The pattern

The *same person* predictably lines up across both — because of a shared underlying vision.

- ▶ A **pre-analytic** hunch about how the social world works — held before the evidence.
- ▶ Like a **map**: useful only because it leaves things out.
- ▶ Indispensable for the same reason it is dangerous — when you mistake it for the terrain.

## Everyone has one

The question is not whether you carry a vision. It is whether you know which one.



- ▶ Facts test **theories**, never visions — so a vision outlives its failed theories.
- ▶ **Interests** explain the lobbyist — yet millions with nothing at stake take sides.
- ▶ Interests shift with circumstances; visions persist across centuries.

Sowell

*“Conflicts of interests dominate the short run, but conflicts of visions dominate history.”*

- ▶ **Thomas Sowell** (b. 1930) — economist, Hoover Institution.
- ▶ Trained in price theory under George Stigler at Chicago.
- ▶ Wide-ranging body of work on economics, race, intellectual history, education.
- ▶ *A Conflict of Visions* (1987; rev. 2007) is the entry point to his informal “trilogy” on the politics of ideas.



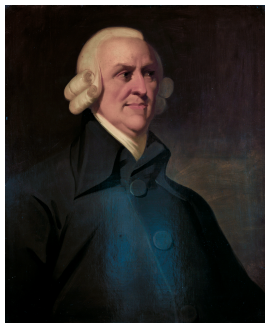
Thomas Sowell

- ▶ All disagreements about politics, economics, and law trace back to one question:  
What kind of being is man?
- ▶ Two answers, two visions:
  - ▶ **Constrained**: man's moral and intellectual limits are inherent and not fixable.
  - ▶ **Unconstrained**: present human flaws are contingent products of bad institutions, correctable.

- ▶ Man's moral and intellectual limits are **inherent** — facts to work with, not defects to cure.
- ▶ Social task: **channel** self-interest through incentives — honor, price, praise — toward public benefit.
- ▶ The best on offer is a wise trade-off within the limits.

## Burke, answering the perfectibilists

*"We cannot change the Nature of things and of men — but must act upon them the best we can."*

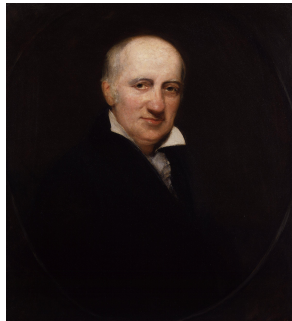


Adam Smith (1723–1790)

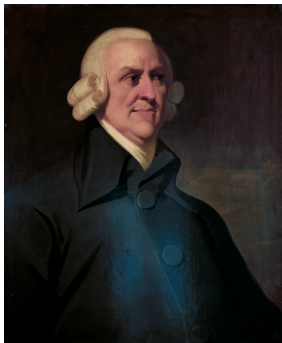
- ▶ Man's flaws are **contingent** — products of circumstance and bad institutions, correctable by reason.
- ▶ Man can weigh a stranger's greater interest above his own.
- ▶ Social task: **dispel** vice and bias, not harness them.

## Godwin

*"Men are capable, no doubt, of preferring an inferior interest of their own to a superior interest of others; but this preference arises from a combination of circumstances and is not the necessary and invariable law of our nature."*



William Godwin (1756–1836)



### Adam Smith, *Theory of Moral Sentiments*

*“... he would pursue his business or his pleasure, take his repose or his diversion, with the same ease and tranquility as if no such accident had happened. . . . If he was to lose his little finger tomorrow, he would not sleep to-night; but, provided he never saw them, he would snore with the most profound security over the ruin of a hundred million of his brethren.”*

— Smith on hearing news of an earthquake in China.

## Constrained

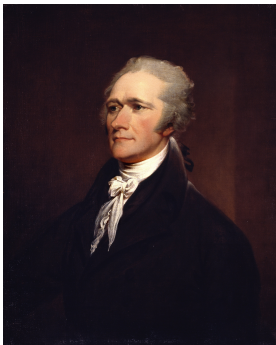
- ▶ No solutions — only **trade-offs**.
- ▶ Prudence: “the first of all virtues” (Burke).
- ▶ The operative question: **compared to what?**

## Unconstrained

- ▶ Genuine **solutions** exist.
- ▶ Prudence: “frigid,” a lower virtue.
- ▶ Man is perfectible: “we can come nearer and nearer” (Godwin).

## Thomas Sowell

*“One of the hallmarks of the constrained vision is that it deals in trade-offs rather than solutions.”*



Alexander Hamilton

### Hamilton, *The Federalist*

*"It is the lot of all human institutions, even those of the most perfect kind, to have defects as well as excellencies — ill as well as good propensities. This results from the imperfection of the Institutor, Man."*



**Hamilton (American, constrained)**

- ▶ Built a **trade-off**: checks and balances.
- ▶ Institutions must contain the imperfection of man.

**Robespierre (French, unconstrained)**

- ▶ Sought a **solution**: virtue enforced through the state.
- ▶ Jefferson, defending it: *“rather than it should have failed, I would have seen half the earth desolated.”*

**Consequences?**

Both revolutions marched under liberty's banner. One produced a durable constitution, the other the Terror. Coincidence — or two visions at work?

- ▶ Ask of any argument: **which vision is speaking?**
- ▶ Like Sowell, we work **positively** first: expose each vision's logic before judging it.

| Part                                               | Dates         | The question                                                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------------------------|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>I. Concepts for PPEL</b>                        | Aug 21–Sep 11 | The toolkit: visions of human nature, the economic way of thinking, division of labor, property rights.                             |
| <b>II. Anarchy and the State</b>                   | Sep 14–Oct 2  | Why a state at all? The state of nature, game theory, is anarchy so bad, origins of the state.                                      |
| <b>III. Politics, Constitutions, and Elections</b> | Oct 5–23      | How collective choice works: the general will, voting paradoxes, constitutional choice, the median voter, democratic failures.      |
| <b>IV. Capitalism and its Critics</b>              | Oct 26–Nov 18 | Does the great modern argument against capitalism succeed? Marx and the socialist critique, knowledge and planning, social justice. |
| <b>V. A Debate in Applied PPEL</b>                 | Nov 30–Dec 2  | The whole toolkit on one live debate the class picks: a duty to vote, a market for organs, a market for citizenship.                |

One thread runs through all five: **the two visions**.

| Component                             | Weight |
|---------------------------------------|--------|
| Reading quizzes (drop 3 lowest)       | 20%    |
| Participation (3 free absences)       | 25%    |
| AI Reading Dialogues ×4 (drop lowest) | 10%    |
| Midterm 1 — Part I                    | 15%    |
| Midterm 2 — Parts II–III              | 15%    |
| Final — Part IV + debate              | 15%    |

All three exams non-cumulative: multiple choice, short answers, a short essay. Participation is graded generously — good faith, not eloquence.

| Date           | What                   |
|----------------|------------------------|
| Fri, Aug 28    | Quiz 1                 |
| Mon, Sep 14    | Midterm 1              |
| Mon, Oct 26    | Midterm 2              |
| Dec 5–11       | Final (Registrar slot) |
| Sep 18, Oct 16 | Dialogues 1–2 due      |
| Oct 30, Nov 13 | Dialogues 3–4 due      |

- ▶ Two MWF sections: PE03 11:45–12:35, PE04 12:50–1:40. Three credits, fully in person, room TBD.
- ▶ Office hours: Wednesday 8:30–11:30 AM and by appointment. Email: [louisrouanetecon@gmail.com](mailto:louisrouanetecon@gmail.com) (preferred) or [louis.rouanet@ufl.edu](mailto:louis.rouanet@ufl.edu).
- ▶ No textbook to buy — every required reading is a PDF, organized by week.

- ▶ **Encouraged**: this course is deliberately AI-forward. Use Claude or ChatGPT freely.
- ▶ **Required**: four AI Reading Dialogues. Graded on **your** side of the conversation, not the model's.
- ▶ **Banned**: quizzes and exams are closed book (no AI allowed).

`https://github.com/louisrouanet-econ/ISS2440-PPEL-Fall2026`

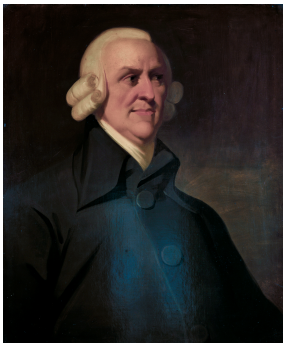
- ▶ One folder per week (Week\_01–Week\_15): readings, slides, and that week's DEADLINES.md.
- ▶ The README is the course at a glance: full weekly schedule and the syllabus PDF.
- ▶ No account needed — browse it like a website. Canvas is only for grades and submissions.



Scan, then bookmark.

- ▶ Unconstrained vision: **intentions** are decisive  $\Rightarrow$  a good society flows from good will.
- ▶ Constrained vision: **incentives** are decisive  $\Rightarrow$  results, not motives, are the test.
- ▶ Smith's merchants create public benefits that are "no part of their intention."





### Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*

*"It is not from the benevolence of the butcher, the brewer, or the baker, that we expect our dinner, but from their regard to their own interest. We address ourselves, not to their humanity but to their self-love, and never talk to them of our own necessities but of their advantages."*





|               | Beneficial                   | Harmful    |
|---------------|------------------------------|------------|
| Intentional   | Virtue                       | Vice       |
| Unintentional | (missing in Godwin's scheme) | Negligence |

## Sowell's point

Godwin's scheme has **no slot for unintentional benefit** — the very category *The Wealth of Nations* puts at the center. That empty cell is Week 2's reading: Bastiat on the seen and the unseen.

## Constrained

- ▶ Knowledge = vast, mostly **inarticulate** social experience.
- ▶ Distilled into prices, customs, language, law.
- ▶ Each person's private stock of reason is small.

## Unconstrained

- ▶ Knowledge = **articulated** reasoning, demonstrable facts.
- ▶ Concentrated in "cultivated minds."
- ▶ Tradition is suspect; reason is paramount.



Edmund Burke

*"We are afraid to put men to live and trade each on his own private stock of reason; because we suspect that this stock in each man is small, and that the individuals would do better to avail themselves of the general bank and capital of nations and of ages."*



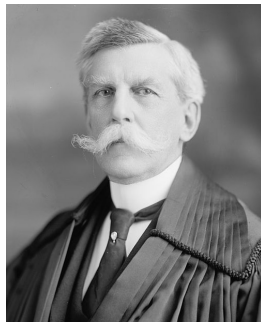
Marquis de Condorcet

*"Everything that bears the imprint of time must inspire distrust more than respect."*

- ▶ **Articulated** rationality: reasons a mind can state  $\Rightarrow$  plans, blueprints, proofs.
- ▶ **Systemic** rationality: reason stored in evolved practice  $\Rightarrow$  language, prices, common law.
- ▶ Nobody invented English. It works anyway.

## Holmes

*"The life of the law has not been logic: it has been experience."*



O. W. Holmes Jr.

|                       | Constrained                  | Unconstrained                 |
|-----------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| <b>Human nature</b>   | Inherently limited           | Perfectible; flaws contingent |
| <b>Mode of action</b> | Trade-offs                   | Solutions                     |
| <b>Intentions</b>     | Often irrelevant to outcomes | Decisive                      |
| <b>Knowledge</b>      | Dispersed, tacit, social     | Concentrated, articulated     |
| <b>Reason</b>         | Systemic, evolved            | Explicit deduction            |
| <b>Exemplars</b>      | Smith, Burke, Hamilton       | Godwin, Condorcet, Rousseau   |

Ideal types, not left vs. right — libertarians, fascists, and Marxists all scramble the map.



- ▶ **Crime** — does poverty cause crime, or does crime simply pay? We run the numbers in Part I: *should we guillotine them all?*
- ▶ **The general will**: Is it well defined? Is it discoverable? Part III tackles those issues.

- ▶ **Poverty** — history's default, not an anomaly someone caused. Part IV grades Marx's predictions.
- ▶ **Knowledge** — today's claim that no planner can gather what millions of minds know becomes, in 1945, the knockout blow of the socialist calculation debate (Part IV).
- ▶ **Social justice** — can an outcome be unjust when no one acted unjustly? Hold your answer until December (Part IV).

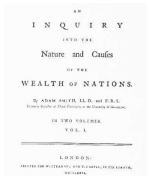
- ▶ The same two lineups recur from Godwin vs. Burke to this morning's feed — visions outlive their authors.
- ▶ So the course keeps circling back: crime, constitutions, planning, social justice — one conflict, many battlefields.

### Sowell

Political compromises between the two visions are *"truces, not peace treaties."*

- ▶ Finish Sowell, chapters 1–3, if you have not.
- ▶ Week 2 reading is on the repo (Week\_02): Bastiat, *What Is Seen and What Is Not Seen* (selections).
- ▶ Quiz 1: in class, Friday, August 28 — closed book, at the start of class.

- ▶ Thomas Sowell, *A Conflict of Visions* (1987; rev. 2007) — this week's text.
- ▶ Thomas Sowell, *The Vision of the Anointed* (1995) — the unconstrained vision in contemporary policy.
- ▶ Thomas Sowell, *The Quest for Cosmic Justice* (1999) — closing volume of the trilogy on the politics of ideas.



*The Wealth of Nations*, 1776 — where Part I picks up the story.